

Creating depth with color

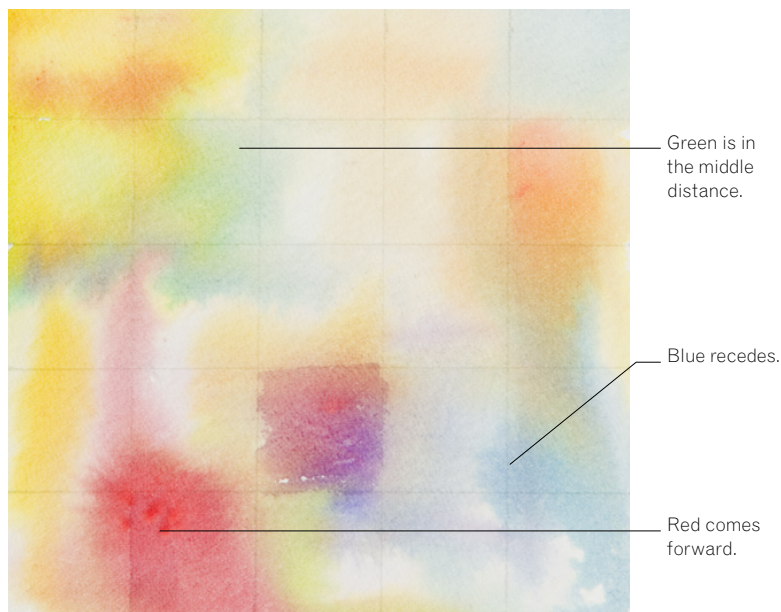
The colors of objects appear to change depending on how near or far they are from you, because of atmospheric conditions. In the foreground, colors are at their warmest and strongest and have the widest range of tones. With distance, colors lose their

intensity, becoming bluer and lighter with less tonal variation. To create a sense of perspective in your paintings, forget what color you think an object is and paint it the color you actually see. This will be determined by how near or far away the object is.

RED COMES FORWARD

The colored grid on the right shows how the warmth, or lack of warmth, of a color affects where it sits in a painting. Warm colors such as reds and oranges appear to come forward, cool blue colors seem to recede, and greens sit in the middle distance.

By positioning warm and cool colors carefully, you can create a sense of depth in the scenes you paint. A simple landscape of green fields with red poppies in the foreground and a distant blue sky immediately has a sense of perspective. On a smaller scale, you can make individual objects look more solid if you paint the part of the object closest to you with warm colors and use cooler colors on the sides of the object, as these are further away from you.

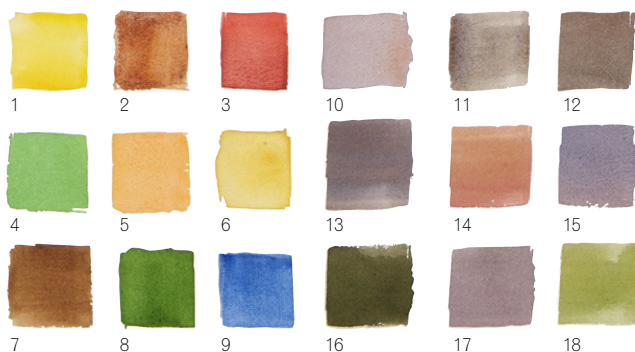


WARM AND COOL PALETTES

Paints are described as warm or cool depending on whether they have a reddish or bluish tone. This varies according to the pigment used to make them. A warm color such as red, for example,

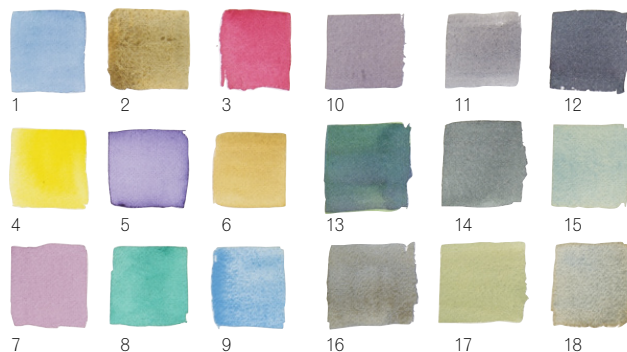
can appear in the cool palette if the pigment used to make it has a bluish tone, as with alizarin crimson. Selecting colors from both palettes in your paintings will help you create perspective.

Warm color palette



1. cadmium yellow 2. burnt sienna 3. cadmium red 4. emerald green
5. cadmium orange 6. raw sienna 7. burnt umber 8. sap green 9. French ultramarine 10–18. neutral mixes.

Cool color palette



1. cobalt blue 2. raw umber 3. alizarin crimson 4. lemon yellow 5. Windsor violet 6. yellow ochre 7. permanent mauve 8. viridian 9. cerulean blue 10–18. neutral mixes.